

lie in the United States of the 1960s. While the All India Pickleball Association (AIPA) was launched in 2008, it wasn't until a few years ago that it picked up in India. Although national-level ranking tournaments have been a regular feature, the highlight was hosting the Bainbridge Cup, considered the Pickleball World Cup, in Mumbai in 2022.

"We had 435 players from 11 countries and the $50,000 prize money really had people sit up and take notice. And it has only grown since then. Today, we have over 10,000 registered players and about 25,000-30,000 in all playing the sport in India," says Nikhil Mathure, treasurer of AIPA.

In a short span, India has done well on the international front too. Earlier this year, the teams picked up 10 medals at the US Open Pickleball Championship and five at the Asian Open Pickleball Championship. AIPA has been doing their bit to increase pickleball's popularity. After finding local manufacturers for equipment, they have been conducting demonstrations at schools and universities, besides going out to smaller towns (19 state associations have been set up so far). "Reducing the financial entry barrier was important to give everyone access. We have a lot of youngsters playing today," says Mathure.

Natekar wants to bring down some top international players to ensure that the league is a spectacle. "We are also making a few other commitments to the franchisees in terms of developing pickleball through talent searches and grassroots programmes. The idea is to build our own heroes through this league," he says. ■

–Shail Desai



AFP

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aspect of his game.

On court, he maintained a high intensity under the watchful eyes of Padukone, coach Vimal Kumar and his father, Dhirendra. To make up for the lack of match practice, training sessions included practice games. "It's rare to get this kind of time in-season, so I knew it was important to put in the work," he recalls.

However, the year started no different. In three tournaments in January, Sen picked up just one win. But he was sensing the improvements with every match and was patient. "The Indonesia Masters was a great boost for my confidence. I was in a better space on the whole, much sharper with good fitness levels," says Sen. The pressure was immense as the competition moved to Europe in March. But with two deep semi-final runs at the French Open and the All England Open, Sen did enough to qualify for his Olympic debut.

"It's been a tough few months, but now it's done. The next few weeks will be about training to keep up fitness levels and playing tournaments to be match-ready," Sen says. And, as he's learnt, being patient. ■

–Shail Desai